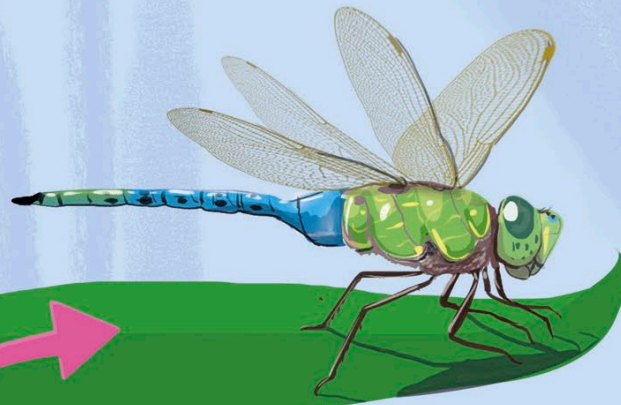


Drying out

The dragonfly waits for its legs and body to harden and its wings to dry out in the sun. Then it begins hunting for food, such as mosquitoes, flies, bees, and butterflies—and it starts searching for a mate.



Dragonfly

Fast-flying dragonflies, like the green darner shown here, dart through the air beside lakes, ponds, and streams. Young dragonflies, called nymphs, look like adults but have no wings. The nymphs change into adults through shedding, or molting, their exoskeletons (outer skeletons). This is called incomplete metamorphosis.



The emerging adult hauls out its soft new body and carefully uncurls its abdomen.

Emerging dragonfly

The nymph leaves the water for good, ready for the last molt of its life. It puffs up its exoskeleton, causing it to split open. The dragonfly wriggles out, ready for life as an adult.



The nymph emerges from its watery world, often by crawling up a plant stem.

Powerful wings allow dragonflies to fly at 30 mph (50 kph).

Molting

Instead of stretchy skin, the nymph has a hard covering called an exoskeleton. It must shed, or molt, its exoskeleton regularly so that it can grow. The stage between each molt is called an instar.



The dragonfly's adult wings start to develop, but for now they remain tucked inside wing pads.

See also

Compare this life cycle with that of the praying mantis (84–85), which also goes through incomplete metamorphosis.